In the normal course, Lt Gen Praveen Bakshi, who was the Army Commander Eastern Command should have succeeded Gen Dalbir Singh Suhag as the COAS, in December 2016. If that had happened, then my coursemate, Lt Gen Devraj Anbu, would have been next in line to become the Chief. However, this whole line-up changed when Gen Bipin Rawat was promoted over the heads of Lt Gen Praveen Bakshi and Lt Gen PM Hariz, both of whom retired in due course. Lt Gen Devraj Anbu, also of the SIKH LI, after his stint as the Army Commander, Northern Command, was the VCOAS and due to retire by end-August 2019. Accordingly, it was decided that I should move to Delhi as the Vice-Chief even if it were to be for a short duration. It was time to bid adieu to Kolkata and Eastern Command, having once again spent just about a year in this assignment. With this transfer, I would have moved five times in five years; Delhi–Ambala–Delhi–Shimla–Kolkata–Delhi.

I was due to take over as the VCOAS on 1 September 2019 and we were winding down the establishment in Kolkata when Veena got a call from our neighbour in Pune that her mother had suffered a stroke and had to be rushed to Emergency. Unfortunately, Veena's sister Uma had just gone to Canada for their daughter Ira's admission, so there was no choice but for Veena to rush to Pune. Her mother had been admitted to the Dinanath Mangeshkar Hospital and scans showed that immediate surgery was required. After Veena left, I wound up the house, went through the formalities of the farewell and reached Pune before the scheduled surgery. The surgery was a success, but her mobility had been seriously affected. My mother-in-law had been a fiercely independent lady and seeing her bedridden made us all extremely sad. It was clear that she would not be able to live by herself any more and that we would have to bring her back to Delhi with us.

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